Anxiety Attack

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38839173.

Rating:	Mature
Archive Warning:	Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)
Relationship:	Castaspella/Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)
Characters:	Castaspella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)
Additional Tags:	Literally the title, Intrusive Thoughts, emotional break down, Hyperventilation, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Even SW couldn't bear seeing that, Casta needs to vent more often, This may seem a bit too strong, So be Careful When Reading, don't worry i'm fine, Kinda, Heavy Angst, Eventual Fluff
Language:	English
Series:	Part 5 of Path 3
Stats:	Published: 2022-05-07 Words: 3,081 Chapters: 1/1

Anxiety Attack

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

On their way to find the means to free Etheria's magic, Castaspella's thoughts haunt her until she can't take it anymore. Unexpectedly, Shadow Weaver will be the one to help her manage these anxiety attacks. To her own surprise, she did it perfectly, and realized a part of her couldn't bear seeing the sorceress in such distress; perhaps she's not exactly gentle, but her concern is very real and exactly what Castaspella needed.

Notes

So...
I know this is very random.

But I needed to make something good with the sh1t I went through today. Honestly, I'm fine; I actually had to go buy clothes before all of that happened, mom encouraged me to do so, and I literally got three garments perfect for some SW outfit, in the exact tone and all, so now I couldn't be happier.
However, I couldn't stop thinking about the feeling I had and the things that could have helped me. So I accidentally came up with this, and it turned out to be really comforting.

And, of course, I totally changed the reason for the anxiety attack, more like, reversed it even. I'm not really sure I should explain further, but let's just say I *wish* my reason was remotely similar...

Whatever, just read at your own risk.
~~I need a SW comforting me like that even if she's simultaneously a bitch about it~~

And, I'm enabling comment moderation just in case, don't be jumpscared heh

That's all <3

See the end of the work for more notes

As they walked through the woods, to who-except-Shadow-Weaver-knows where, Castaspella's thoughts relentlessly resonated in her head.

—Hurry up. We don't know how much time we have before Prime causes irreparable damage to Micah— the dark sorceress reminded her.

—I know, I know. I'm coming— she retorted, annoyed.

But, just how much time did they have?

What if Prime had already made him hurt someone?

What if he had made him use risky magic?

What if Micah was already hurt yet going on because that chip ordered so?

How could she let this happen?

Again.

Why wasn't she there for him?

Again.

Why did she let them take him from her?

Again!

Her thoughts raced, self-blame rose, her heart beat anxiously and her breathing quickened.

With a gasp, she fell to her knees, holding her head; it became so hard to breathe that she began gasping harshly, feeling like she lacked oxygen, but the more she tried to breathe, the worse that asphyxia felt.

—What is- Uh!?— Shadow Weaver was ready to rush her again, but as soon as she turned around, she interrupted herself, bewildered. *What* had happened!? —Castaspella— she called out, but the sorceress wasn't listening.

The hyperventilation became worse with each passing second, and the thoughts became even worse.

Why weren't you there?

You abandoned him.

Why didn't you do anything*!?*

You left him alone again.

How could you lose him again when you had just *recovered him?*

This is all your fault.

She couldn't stop the accusatory thoughts, no matter how much she tried to tell herself none of that was true. Her thoughts were starting to convince her. She was almost out of air, breathing felt impossible and strained whines were the only thing escaping her throat.

She was sure she'd pass out, until a hand grabbed her shoulder. She didn't process anything happening from then on; another hand grabbed her other shoulder and pushed her a bit to straighten her back. Then, both hands were holding her face, grounding her as she stared at a red mask.

For a moment, she could only focus on the white sockets, which widened as the woman spoke to her.

But it took her another second to recover her senses enough to finally hear —Castaspella! Breathe!

She tried and failed.

—I- Ah- I-

—Breathe— the woman insisted, noticing her struggle. Shadow Weaver kneeled in front of her, withdrew a hand for a moment to take off her mask, and grabbed her face again, repeating —Breathe.

She took a deep breath and exhaled, exhorting Castaspella to copy her, but it barely worked at first. After a few more seconds, the sorceress was finally breathing again, trying to heed Shadow Weaver yet still unable to take deep breaths for a moment.

—Ah… I- Ah…

—Don't talk. Not now— the dark sorceress interrupted her. She slowly released her face, but her breathing quickened again so she grabbed her once more and moved her face closer, whispering —Don't think. Focus on your breath, don't rush it.

It took her about ten minutes to recover a normal breathing rhythm, but she slowly relaxed enough for Shadow Weaver to let go of her.

Castaspella was extremely tired, she ran out of strength, and fell to her left. The dark sorceress barely caught her before she hit the ground, and hesitated for a moment before pulling her to rest on her lap.

Castaspella felt relieved; her thoughts had stopped, it had all quietened down. She rested and tried to even her breathing for a few more minutes until she managed to speak again.

—Thank you— she muttered.

—What happened?

—I- It's- Agh… I-

The sorceress began stammering, then choked as the knot in her trachea returned when she tried to explain herself.

—Stop, just… forget it for now— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

But she wanted to say it. She felt terrible, ashamed even, and pushed through the lump in her throat.

—I- I was… thinking. It's- Thi-thinking that… we're- we don't… know… what he- what he could- what could happen to him!— she finally managed to utter.

—He will be alright. We will save him— Shadow Weaver sentenced, looking serious yet still concerned. —We can, and *will*, make sure no harm comes to him.

—And if… he's- he's already hurt?

—We'll undo it.

—How?

—By any means necessary.

Castaspella took a deep shaky breath and exhaled as slowly as she could. She tried to get up, but her arms couldn't even push her up.

—Ugh… I can't…

—You should rest— Shadow Weaver interrupted her.

—But… you said… we were running out… of time— she reminded her.

—I shouldn’t have said that.

—But it's true.

—Perhaps, but you can't continue now, you're in terrible shape. It makes no difference.

Shadow Weaver helped her sit and held her by the shoulders for a moment. They would have to rest right there, but it would be difficult seeing how she had no magic and Castaspella wasn't in conditions to properly cast anything.

It only occurred to her one possibility, so she let the sorceress sit on her own and took a few steps towards a clearing spacious enough for them that would allow them to set a makeshift camp. She kneeled, drew a sigil on the ground, and then moved away from it to draw another one.

She went back for Castaspella and helped her up. They reached the clearing and Shadow Weaver let her sit next to the sigils she had drawn.

—What’s…

—Don't think about it. You know how to cast, just copy these and activate the spells.

The sorceress didn't argue, not like she had the strength for it either, and reached for the larger one. She let her magic pour out, following the pattern just like new pupils are instructed to do, and once complete activated it.

A warm fire slowly rose and quickly warmed up the area around it.

—Oh… that's…

—Useful. Now this one— Shadow Weaver interrupted her. Castaspella sighed and turned to the other sigil drawn on the ground. The dark sorceress was kneeling at the other side and, before letting her cast it, asked —Do you recall any place that has blankets or something? You can't rest on the ground.

She nodded weakly and proceeded just like with the other spell. Fortunately, Shadow Weaver was right and it barely required a minimum effort, so she managed to teleport a large blanket.

—Ah… There’s just one left— she noticed. —I'm sorry…

—Don't. Just lay down for a while, I'll go sit nearby.

The dark sorceress stood up and went for her mask before returning to sit against the closest tree. Castaspella felt too weak to argue or do anything more than dropping down right there. And so she did.

She managed to cover herself with a part of the blanket while resting on the other; keeping her back to the fire, she closed her eyes and tried to sleep.

But it wasn't that easy.

Her thoughts returned, little by little grew louder, and before she noticed, she was almost hyperventilating again.

She had lasted mere minutes.

A hand on her side made Castaspella open her eyes and she saw that mask once again.

—I can't… sleep.

—I can see that— she replied, mocking her a bit. —No more of that. You have to sleep— she then sentenced, more serious. Shadow Weaver hesitated for a moment but finally sighed and took off the mask as she said —Come here.

The woman laid down next to her and hesitated once more as she pulled her into an embrace. Castaspella was tense at first but, soon enough, new tears fell and she snuggled closer, bringing her cold hands up between them; she felt protected, ironically enough.

—I- Thank you— she let out, stammering.

—No need. It was… my fault. Again.

—I can't… believe I broke down.

Shadow Weaver scoffed and reminded her —You're the type who keeps all emotions in control; that interrogation proved as much. It was high time you let this out.

—How strange… hearing that from you— Castaspella admitted.

—I expected you to lash out, I expected you to cry as soon as you knew about Micah. But you were… too calm.

—I have to— she uttered, sorrowful.

—No, you don't. *This* happens when you do.

—I can't just… break down like this, nor can I lash out like you— she retorted, angry yet pressing herself closer to the dark sorceress. —I'm supposed to be an example; I'm in charge of Mystacor, I just can't…

—Fair enough— she sighed. —That position is cursed in my opinion.

—At least I wasn't swallowed into who-knows-where.

Shadow Weaver let out a loud laugh, inadvertently holding Castaspella closer. She was not expecting that, and neither was the sorceress.

—Just sleep already. Or do I have to *manipulate* you into doing so?

—Shut up.

About an hour later, Castaspella woke up, surprised for a moment to still be in Shadow Weaver’s embrace, but it was warm enough that she didn't want to leave just yet. She let out a sigh and relaxed once more until the dark sorceress woke up too and looked down at her.

—You’re finally awake.

—Yes, um… Thank you.

Castaspella’s whisper was barely audible, but she heard it clearly and couldn’t help looking away, feeling awkward with this whole situation until the memory of the sorceress breaking down returned.

After a short while, they finally convinced themselves to get up and continue their trip, but Shadow Weaver thought about something she’d probably regret.

—There’s a stream nearby. You should go freshen up.

—But… we've lost enough time already— Castaspella pointed out.

—Yet you still look terrible. A few more minutes won't make much of a difference; your state of mind will— the dark sorceress insisted.

She sighed, took a few steps, but stopped again. She felt too tired and didn't really want to do this.

—I'm… exhausted. I-I don't have the strength to do this.

Normally, Shadow Weaver would simply let her stay like that and rush her again, but something about her poor physical and mental state, that shallow look and defeated expression, kept pushing her to make decisions she'd hate later.

—In that case…— she sighed, hesitating again. —Allow me to help— she offered. Castaspella was shocked but barely stared in silence as she couldn't really react much. —No ulterior motives, I promise.

Could a promise from her be trusted?

Whatever the answer was, the sorceress couldn't actually give it much importance. She had realized she seriously needed to freshen up, so she accepted and they both went down to the stream.

About twenty minutes later, Shadow Weaver was almost done with Castaspella's hair. She could barely believe the relief she felt when she noticed the sorceress' expression return to her usual.

—I really mean it. Thank you— she insisted once again. —I wouldn't have expected… this, from you.

—I didn't expect it from myself either— she replied, mockingly. —But, it's better than to see you break down so pathetically.

—Shut up— Castaspella laughed. However, after hearing that, she couldn't help but reflect —Does that mean… you didn't like… seeing me like that?

—Why would I?

—I- No, well, I didn't mean you'd like it, but perhaps- I suppose I expected you to remain impassive.

—And I was… I suppose— she replied, hesitant again. —Don't ask me, I myself don't know, nor do I want to— she sentenced, uninterested.

Castaspella giggled, noticed Shadow Weaver had just finished rinsing her hair, and prepared the spell to dry it out. She looked at the dark sorceress as she tied her hair up as usual and noticed how, maskless, she seemed more approachable.

—Can I ask…

—No— she immediately interrupted, anticipating Castaspella's question.

—How rude— she complained as she stood up and walked back into the forest. —What is she playing?— she wondered, speaking through her teeth.

Shadow Weaver joined her shortly after, mask back in place, and they continued their search for a way to free the magic of the planet.

Hours went by, their efforts seemed to be in vain, until they finally found a series of old murals. Castaspella had no trouble interpreting them, but Shadow Weaver had to clarify a few bits of information that even the Head Sorceress didn't know about.

And later...

They hadn't even walked half the way back when a loud commotion called their attention.

—We can't interfere; this isn't our fight— Shadow Weaver told her, but the sorceress rushed to where the sound came from. —What are you- Ugh!

Castaspella was almost out of the woods when she finally saw what was happening: A small village was being attacked. *By sorcerers*.

—No— she sighed, pained.

This was her fault.

How could you abandon your people?

Look what they are doing now.

How could you let Prime take control of them?

This is on you; if blood is spilled, it will be on your hands.

You just had to *rest and delay it all, didn't you?*

This is all your fault.

—Casta. Casta!— Shadow Weaver called, shaking her by the shoulders. —We have to leave, get up!

Castaspella hadn't even noticed when she fell on her knees, and now didn't even resist as the dark sorceress shook her.

—No… Leave me here.

—Don't be dramatic right now, woman.

—Leave me.

—Stop.

—I failed.

—Not yet!

Shadow Weaver grunted, annoyed, as she couldn't convince the sorceress, and gave up. She walked back into the woods, wanting to return as soon as possible and deliver the information about the failsafe and set the plan in motion.

However, she hesitated once again. The hopeless expression of the Head Sorceress was burnt on the back of her brain and she couldn't stop thinking about that. Her stomach turned into stone, part of her shouting that she had to leave, it had been her own fault, and part of her screaming "She needs you, don't leave her!".

Why had she let the woman get into her head?

Shadow Weaver stalked back, grunting annoyed, and immediately picked up the woman as she could, almost dragging her back into the safety of the forest. The sorceress was already choking, unable to breathe, tears fell on both sides of her face, her eyes had reddened, and she madly grasped the ground. Castaspella was practically doomed, the dark sorceress didn't have the first idea what to do, and soon was getting worried enough to start panicking.

But she couldn't let that happen.

After having sat her against a tree, Shadow Weaver kneeled in front of her, desperately trying to shake her out of that state. But it seemed impossible and the dark sorceress grew frantic. The mask felt suffocating, as if it were now that Castaspella induced her the hyperventilation, so she tore it off, threw it to the side, and gasped for air.

It was a sensation, just a sensation.

The dark sorceress looked down at her again and noticed Castaspella could pass out any moment soon, so she grabbed her face once more, like she had done the last time, but now pressed their foreheads together. She couldn't utter a word, but it seemed to be working and the sorceress little by little breathed again, slowing down.

They remained like that for a few minutes, eyes closed, foreheads together, Shadow Weaver holding Castaspella's face between her hands, and the both of them finally calmed down, gradually recovering.

—I'm… sorry…

—Forget it— the dark sorceress sighed. —It doesn't matter.

—I am…

—This isn't your fault. *None of this*.

—But it is…

—It is not.

—Why? How… are you so- so sure?

—Your head is *lying* to you— Shadow Weaver sentenced, grabbing her chin and tilting her face up to look at her. —You're too stubborn. Just stop thinking.

She tried to reply but couldn't, just stared at her instead, tearing up; the dark sorceress noticed her trembling lips, that she had stopped breathing once again, and didn't even blink now.

Be it because she was in shock, or because impulse overtook her, Shadow Weaver pulled her in for a kiss. Curiously enough, Castaspella corresponded immediately. The kiss was quickly broken by their need to breathe deeply, but at least the sorceress was finally back in her senses.

—I… tha-thank you…

Shadow Weaver couldn't support her own weight, especially because the relief of hearing her speak again had just depleted the last of her strength, and she almost fell on Castaspella. The sorceress caught her and rested back on the tree, holding Shadow Weaver between her arms.

—You can be… *very* difficult to handle, eh?— she laughed, breathless. —You better start letting out… all of this anxiety.

Castaspella didn't have the strength to laugh too, but looked down at her only to notice those split eyes looking back. Without thinking, she closed the distance and kissed her again. Shadow Weaver felt a pain in the middle of her chest that quickly passed the more they kissed.

The sorceress had roped her into this mess of feelings, hadn't she?

They rested there for the night. Shadow Weaver had thought about returning right then, but she was sure they wouldn't last much before passing out. Instead, they set camp once again, agreed to leave early so they could arrive around nightfall, and rested together just like last time.

They were almost too comfortable in each other's embrace, and neither of them wanted to lose this; while Castaspella still kept in mind who this woman is, she couldn't simply ignore how much she had done for her, and the feeling of safety she now has, just like Shadow Weaver keeps telling herself she just pities the sorceress yet can't help the waves of relief that overwhelm her each time Castaspella takes a calm even breath.

—Um…

—What?

—Sorry, it's just…

—I know. Don't worry, no one will realize.

—Easy for you to say.

—If you think you'll give yourself away, then I'll just give you reasons to be annoyed at me as much as possible.

—Shut up— she laughs. —I'm sure that will only backfire.

—Perhaps. But…— Shadow Weaver began, with a slightly teasing tone. —The mere *thought* of this being possible will be automatically discarded by them all, don't you think? Who would believe…

—I get it— Castaspella interrupted her, tightening her embrace. —Just to, you know, be sure.

The dark sorceress huffed amusedly and pulled her closer. They both relaxed little by little and eventually drifted to sleep.

End Notes

I hope that was more interesting than concerning, heh

Um, and, yeah. That's it.

Thank you for reading.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!